95.5% of ethanol and 4.5% of water. This is called **rectified spirit**. This mixture is then refluxed over quicklime for about 5 to 6 hours and then allowed to stand for 12 hours. On distillation of this mixture, pure alcohol (100%) is obtained. This is called **absolute alcohol**.

More to know

Yeast and Fermentation: Yeasts are single–celled microorganisms, belonging to the class of fungi. The enzymes present in yeasts catalyse many complex organic reactions. Fermentation is conversion of complex organic molecules into simpler molecules by the action of enzymes. E.g. Curdling of milk

11.6.2 Physical properties

i) Ethanol is a colourless liquid, having a pleasant smell and a burning taste.

ii) It is a volatile liquid. Its boiling point is 78º C (351K), which is much higher than that of its corresponding alkane, i.e. ethane (Boiling Point = 184 K).

iii) It is completely miscible with water in all proportions.

11.6.3 Chemical Properties

(i) Dehydration (Loss of water)

When ethanol is heated with con H_2SO_4 at 443K, it loses a water molecule i.e. dehydrated to form ethene.

$$\underset{\text{Ethanol}}{CH_3CH_2OH} \xrightarrow[443K]{Conc.H_2SO_4} \underset{\text{Ethene}}{CH_2 = CH_2} + H_2O$$

(ii) Reaction with sodium:

Ethanol reacts with sodium metal to form sodium ethoxide and hydrogen gas.

$$2C_2H_5OH + 2Na \longrightarrow \underset{\text{sodium ethoxide}}{2C_2H_5ONa} + H_2 \uparrow$$

(iii) Oxidation:

Ethanol is oxidized to ethanoic acid with alkaline $KMnO_4$ or acidified $K_2Cr_2O_7$

$$CH_3CH_2OH \xrightarrow[2[O]]{K_2Cr_2O_7 / H^+} \underset{\text{Ethanoic acid}}{CH_3COOH} + H_2O$$

During this reaction, the orange colour of $K_2Cr_2O_7$ changes to green. Therefore, this reaction can be used for the identification of alcohols.

(iv) Esterification:

The reaction of an alcohol with a carboxylic acid gives a compound having fruity odour. This compound is called an **ester** and the reaction is called esterification. Ethanol reacts with ethanoic acid in the presence of conc. H_2SO_4 to form ethyl ethanoate, an ester.

$$\underset{\text{Ethanol}}{C_2H_5OH} + \underset{\text{Ethanoic acid}}{CH_3COOH} \xrightarrow{conc.H_2SO_4} \underset{\text{Ethyl ethanoate}}{CH_3COOC_2H_5} + H_2O$$

(v) Dehydrogenation:

When the vapour of ethanol is passed over heated copper, used as a catalyst at 573 K, it is dehydrogenated to acetaldehyde.

$$\underset{\text{Ethanol}}{CH_3CH_2OH} \xrightarrow[573K]{Cu} \underset{\text{Acetadehyde}}{CH_3CHO} + H_2\uparrow$$

(vi) Combustion:

Ethanol is highly inflammable liquid. It burns with oxygen to form carbon dioxide and water.

$$\underset{\text{Ethanol}}{C_2H_5OH} + 3O_2 \longrightarrow \underset{\text{Carbon dioxide}}{2CO_2} + 3H_2O$$

11.6.4 Uses of ethanol

Ethanol is used

- in medical wipes, as an antiseptic.
- as an anti-freeze in automobile radiators.
- for effectively killing micro organisms like bacteria, fungi, etc., by including it in many hand sanitizers.

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